surmised by working backwards from the time when he was anointed emperor, for which we have a reasonably accurate date. This accuracy for his ascension is because his years as emperor have been synchronized with the reigns of contemporary rulers in Asia and beyond: their dates are fairly certain, and several of them are mentioned by name in Ashoka's inscriptions, including Antiochus II Theos of the Seleucid kingdom, Ptolemy II Philadelphus of Egypt, Antigonus II Gonatas of Macedon, Magas of Cyrene, and Alexander of Epirus (or Corinth).[3] These kings and the context in which they are alluded to in Ashoka's epigraphs will be elaborated later; for the present it suffices that arriving at an accurate chronology for Ashoka has involved looking at overlaps in the chronology of these kings and the inscriptions in which they figure.

The emperor's consecration is likely to have taken place around 269/268 BCE.[4] As with several other kings in ancient India whose lives were described in regnal years, Ashoka anchored the various happenings in his reign in relation to the year of his consecration.[5] He is, in fact, the earliest known monarch of ancient India to have recorded events from the time when he was anointed. Many rulers, for centuries afterwards, such as the Satavahanas of western India, the Palas in the east, and the Cholas in peninsular India, would continue with this practice of recording events in relation to the time elapsed since the consecration of the king in question.[6] But there were other monarchs who, by the first century BCE, had begun to indicate events in terms of a more continuous era, where the continuity was reckoned in relation to the reign of a given king by his successors (and which could continue even after that dynasty had ceased to exist).[7] Inscriptions of the time of the Gupta line of rulers were frequently in this format: the Sarnath epigraph is dated to the Gupta year 154 ('a century of years increased by fifty-four'), this being the time of Kumaragupta II, with the year possibly suggesting that the era originated with the first 'Maharajadhiraja' of the dynasty, Chandragupta I.[8] Many rulers in their